

Are Distro Release Cycles Too Short?

We bring you the thoughts of the open source community on this hot topic...

The regularity with which different flavours of the Linux distributions keep arriving in the market has revolutionised the open source landscape. And these are not just the tried-and-tested operating systems for the big servers or for geeks, but are now on desktops as operating systems for regular computer users. Different Linux distros come with varied customisation options, and you can personalise them to suit your needs.

Many of these distros follow a six-monthly release cycle, and there is a general feeling among users that this is too fast and should be slowed down. So, at *OSFY*, we decided to get the reactions from the open source circuit and posed the following question on our Facebook page, addressed to the members of the various Linux User Groups (LUG): “Are distro release cycles too short?” And this question generated quite a buzz and triggered some interesting comments from the communities.

Dave Carollo, an active member of our Facebook community, feels that with the advancement of technology, the release cycles too should be short, with distros coming out with really good updates. He says, “Technology is constantly evolving. Six to nine months is good, as long as upgrading is a smooth process. Those who do not update take a huge security risk in not doing so.”

Rahul Gaur, another member of *OSFY*'s FB community, loves distro-hopping and says he wouldn't mind trying his hand at a new distro every six months or so. “Typically, I do tend to hop from one distro to another as soon as I feel I am getting too comfortable with a particular distro. However, I've never found a smooth and efficient way to upgrade. I am using Fedora 19 now with a clean install from F 17,” he says. Tom Sidock, yet another active contributor on our FB community, comes up with an interesting comment. “Short release cycles facilitate testing and development. I prefer that distributions with short release cycles present a Long Term Support (LTS) version that gets support for

three to five years. I find these LTS releases are solid and get even better as time goes on. I have short release machines, because it can be fun to live on the cutting edge. I always

have the two husband-and-wife machines on the LTS versions, and they just run and run. Good for the relationship too!” writes Tom, with tongue firmly in cheek.

While most of them vouch for shorter and quicker distro release cycles, there are quite a few ardent supporters of longer release cycles as they feel shorter cycles hamper the robustness of the distro. 3rd Coast Geeks, another member of our FB page, is quick to comment: “Stability is important in the production environment.”



What the LUG members have to say

Revant Nandgaonkar, a die-hard Ubuntu fan, turned to Linux Mint Debian Edition (LMDE) only to switch back to Ubuntu. He uses FOSS for personal computing and doesn't like the idea of rolling and the shorter releases which LMDE offers. “I think rolling releases are for continuous testing and development, and not for daily personal computing. What I experienced was that the fixed release distros had all-new FOSS developments well polished and integrated into a distro. I'm happy with the fixed release cycle and LTS system of Ubuntu,” says Nandgaonkar.

For R K Rajeev from ILUG Bombay, who is an avid Fedora user, the six monthly cycle is good. “I typically have my laptop on even versions, and my desktop on odd versions, so I effectively upgrade each system once a year, except for a short time when I buy a new laptop. So I have been following an yearly release cycle and have been on this pattern for almost eight years now. However, I see this changing soon, at least with Fedora. They are making it simpler to upgrade and stay current, especially with the new ‘fedup’-based upgrade process. With easy package management and an army of dedicated package maintainers updating popular packages to the latest version